



Andy Weir's Artemis

Andy Weir, the author of the novel 'The Martian' has a new book, and it's about a crime story set on the moon. <http://digit.in/ArtemisA>



Quora launches ad platform

The question-and-answer site is opening its 'self-serve ad platform' to the public which was first launched in April 2016. <http://digit.in/selfAd>

To the Moon

The world's first privately funded moon landing could be from India - thanks to Team Indus.

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ne of the five remaining teams in Google's Lunar XPrize competition, Team Indus needs no

introduction to space geeks worldwide. Over the years since the announcement of the XPrize, they have conquered milestone after milestone until they are finally looking at a launch aboard an ISRO PSLV later this year. However, the journey so far wasn't a walk in the park - if anything, it was a flight. Let us explore how a team of four enthusiastic engineers from India went on to become one of the leading contenders in the race to privatising the exploration of the Moon.

SPUR OF THE MOMENT

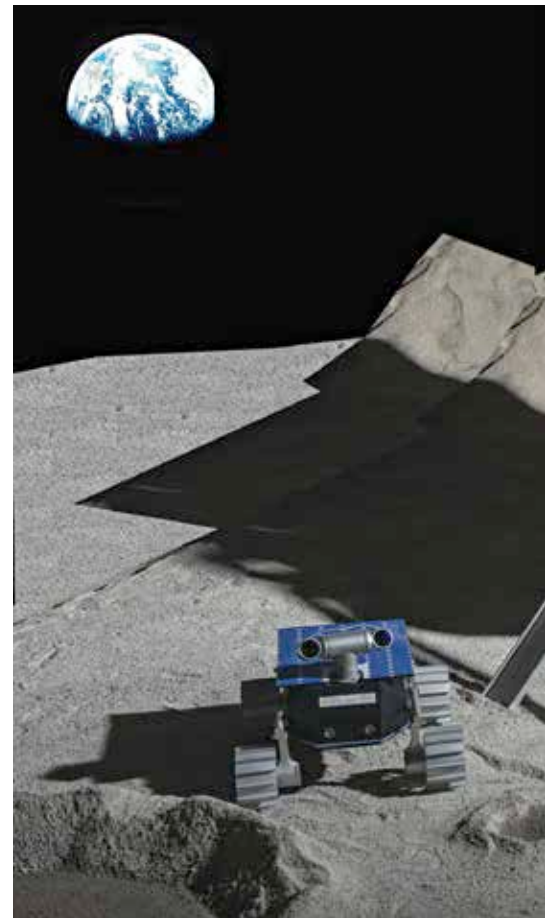
Back in the day when Rahul Narayan was a full fledged IT professional, over a screen-shared call with a client he chanced upon the Google Lunar XPrize as a wallpaper. With his curiosity piqued, he dug deeper and realised that he could lend his software expertise to any Indian team in the competi-

tion - that is, until he found out on the very last day of registration that there were no Indian teams enrolled. A spur of the moment and a couple of months later, Team Indus had registered for the competition with funds arranged by Narayan himself and soon enough, Narayan and his initial teammates were Googling "how to get a spacecraft".

INITIAL CHALLENGES

Having made the dive head-first, Team Indus spent most of 2012 hiring more team members and formulating a feasible mission design. The team comprises of quite a few ex-ISRO scientists, apart from aerospace engineers from across the nation. 2013 was dedicated towards actually demarcating areas that needed to be tackled and restructuring the workforce of the organisation to achieve that. From there, till today, they have 12 different subsystems, and as many departments, in the organisation, some of which are:

- Structures team
- Thermal design team
- Mission team



- Microelectronics team
- Software team
- Flight dynamics team
- Communications team
- Rover team

At that point, they were staring at overcoming the numerous technical challenges, and along with those, the single biggest hurdle - funds. Towards the end of 2013, an announcement from the XPrize foundation posed new challenges, and new opportunities along with it.

TECHNICAL CHALLENGES

One of their first specific technical challenges came in the form of the Terrestrial Milestone prizes. Towards the end of 2013, with only two more years at that point to achieve the goal of landing on the moon, The Google Lunar XPrize foundation felt a deadlock in most team's work. One of the primary reasons behind this was a global